

Ellipsis as leverage for dependent case theory*

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1. Introduction

Coined by Ross (1969), sluicing refers to ellipsis constructions in which a *wh*-expression, also known as the *wh*-remnant, appears without an overt clausal complement but is interpreted against an *antecedent clause* as exemplified in (1).

- (1) Somebody_{*i*} just left—guess who_{*i*}. (Ross 1969)

Sluicing has been central to debates about whether there is silent syntactic structure in the *ellipsis site* following the *wh*-remnant. Support for the presence of internal syntax comes from various *connectivity effects* (following Merchant 2018). Properties of *wh*-remnants seem to be determined by the syntax of the antecedent clause. One such effect is case matching, where a *wh*-remnant bears the same case as its correlate in the antecedent. The empirical puzzle in this paper comes from the distribution of case on *wh*-remnants in a construction, which I refer to as *low sluicing* in Turkish (Kiper 2025). In this construction, the remnant of an elliptical question is not merely a case-marked *wh*-phrase, as in canonical sluicing, but a morphologically rich constituent bearing a copular morpheme (analyzed as auxiliary here) and tense.¹ Crucially, while many case-marked *wh*-remnants are grammatical in low sluicing (e.g., dative, ablative, locative or instrumental/commitative), *structural cases* such as accusative and genitive assigned to the subjects of nominalizations fail to surface, despite being present on the correlate in the antecedent clause. The accusative pattern is illustrated in (2) and the genitive pattern in (3).

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¹The so-called copula is realized null after consonants, *-y-* after vowels and *i* as a free-standing morpheme (Kornfilt 1996, 1997).

- (2) Çayan birisi-ni_i gör-dü ama kim(*-i)_i-y-di
 Çayan.NOM someone-ACC see-PST but who-ACC-AUX-PST
 bil-mi-yor-um.
 know-NEG-IPFV-1SG
 Int. ‘Çayan saw someone but I don’t know who.’
- (3) Çayan [birisi-nin_i gel-diğ-in]_i-i söyle-di ama
 Çayan.NOM [someone-GEN come-NMLZ-POSS.3SG]-ACC say-PST but
 kim(*-in)_i-Ø-di bil-mi-yor-um.
 who-GEN-AUX-PST know-NEG-IPFV-1SG
 Int. ‘Çayan said that someone came but I don’t know who.’

At first sight, this case disconnectivity might seem to follow from a copular clause source for low sluicing. Since *wh*-remnants bear auxiliary and tense morphology, one might analyze them as predicates of copular clauses, where structural cases would be independently unavailable. In Section 2, however, I show with a series of diagnostics that low sluicing allows configurations unavailable in ordinary copular clauses, but expected under a full clausal source. The absence of structural case on the remnants therefore cannot simply be treated as a surface property of copular predicates.

The resulting pattern therefore raises a deeper question: *why* do structural cases fail precisely in a construction that otherwise has a full clausal source involving the configurations required for their assignment? In Section 3, I propose that the absence of structural case in low sluicing follows from the interaction between the properties of the ellipsis-licensing head and the theory of case assignment at play. In particular, I argue that the [E]-feature on the Aux head freezes the material in its complement for later case computation. This account depends on a configurational view of case, where DPs inside the domain marked for deletion cannot enter into the larger configurational relations required for case assignment. Section 4 demonstrates how *wh*-remnants that would otherwise be eligible for accusative or genitive cannot receive case and surface with unmarked nominative instead. Section 5 concludes.

The paper makes two contributions. First, it shows that ellipsis licensing can do more than silence material at PF: it can affect the accessibility of material inside the ellipsis site for later syntactic computation, building on work that treats ellipsis licensing as syntactically active (Aelbrecht 2010). Second, it provides new leverage for a configurational view of structural case.

2. The syntax of low sluicing

The explanation for the case disconnectivity of low sluicing depends on the underlying syntax in the ellipsis site. I follow a major line of research in taking sluicing to involve deletion of syntactically represented clausal material (e.g., Ross 1969, Sag 1976, Merchant 2001). Under this approach, the remnant in (1) originates inside an interrogative clause and moves out of the constituent targeted by ellipsis, as illustrated in (4). This kind of clausal source

accounts for the case matching between the remnant and the correlate straightforwardly (Merchant 2001, 2018).

- (4) Somebody_i just left—guess who_i [~~*t_i*~~ just left].

A related view maintains syntactic structure in the ellipsis site but denies that the source must always be fully identical (or *isomorphic*) to the antecedent. On this view, some sluicing strings may instead involve non-isomorphic sources such as copular clauses (Vicente 2008, van Craenenbroeck 2010, Gribanova 2013, Barros et al. 2014). Under such an analysis, the remnant in (1) is not extracted from a clause parallel to the antecedent, but it is the predicate of an elided copular clause as schematized in (5).

- (5) Somebody_i just left—guess who_i [~~it is *t_i*~~].

Turkish provides an ideal testing ground to compare these views. It exhibits two sluicing constructions, distinguished by whether the wh-remnant bears only case or also auxiliary and tense. In high sluicing, the wh-remnant matches the case of the correlate as in (6a). In low sluicing, the wh-remnant additionally bears auxiliary and tense morphology as in (6b).

- (6) Çayan biri-ne_i fena sinirlen-di
Çayan.NOM someone-DAT badly get.mad-PST
'Çayan got really mad at someone.'

- a. ama kim-e_i bil-mi-yor-um.
but who-DAT know-NEG-IPFV-1 SG
'but I don't know who.'

high sluicing

- b. ama kim-e_i-y-di bil-mi-yor-um.
but who-DAT-AUX-PST know-NEG-IPFV-1 SG
'but I don't know who it was.'

low sluicing

For both types of sluicing, there is broad consensus that the source of the ellipsis is not a cleft construction (Ince 2006, Ince 2009, Palaz 2018, Şener 2012, Zidani-Eroğlu 2019; pace Kizu 1997, Hankamer 2011). However, the case disconnectivity goes unnoticed in all of these works, which potentially might change the picture since it gives leverage to a copular clause analysis for low sluicing especially considering the copular morpheme on the remnants. I argue, however, that low sluicing strings cannot be reduced to predicates of copular clauses. Despite their similar surface form, they pattern with genuine clausal ellipsis in allowing multiple wh-remnants and adjunct remnants, and they are island-sensitive unlike copular clauses. I therefore analyze low sluicing as deletion of a verbal projection, following the basic direction of Ince (2006), but with a different licensing mechanism: deletion is licensed by Aux, the head that hosts the copular morphology.

2.1 Against a copular clause source

The copular morphology in low sluicing suggests a compelling alternative to a full clausal source. Under this view, the ellipsis site would contain a null pronominal subject and a wh-predicate, as schematized in (7).

- (7) [CP [TP [AuxP [Small Clause [DP ... *pro*] [DP ... WH]] Aux] T] C]

Since simple copular clauses do not assign accusative and do not involve embedded clause structure that requires genitive, the absence of structural cases on wh-remnants would follow straightforwardly without further assumptions. However, I present three arguments below for why copular clauses cannot be the only source for low sluicing.

First and foremost, low sluicing allows multiple wh-remnants as illustrated in (8a).² However, copular clauses cannot host multiple predicates as exemplified in (8b).³

- (8) Çayan **biri-ne** **bir şey** ver-di
 Çayan.NOM someone-DAT one thing.NOM give-PST
 ‘Çayan gave something to someone.’
- a. ama (ben) **kim-e** **ne-y-di** bil-mi-yor-um.
 but 1SG who-DAT what.NOM-AUX-PST know-NEG-IPFV-1SG
 ‘but I don’t know whom what.’
- b. *[?]ve **Figen’e** **para-y-dı** san-dı-m.
 and Figen.DAT money.NOM-AUX-PST assume-PST-1SG
 Lit. ‘and I assumed it was money for Figen.’

Second, low sluicing in Turkish is island-sensitive. This contrasts both with high sluicing in Turkish and with sluicing in English, which are well-known to be island-insensitive (Ross 1969, Merchant 2001). The high sluicing example in (9a) is acceptable even though the correlate is inside a complex NP island. Low sluicing behaves differently: as shown in (9b), it fails when the correlate is contained inside the same island. The corresponding copular clause in (9c), on the other hand, remains grammatical, as expected if no extraction from the island is involved.

- (9) Çayan [Figen’in **biri-ne** yüklü bir miktar-da para
 Çayan.NOM Figen.GEN someone-DAT large one amount-LOC money.NOM
 ver-diğ-i] dedikodu-su-nu duy-du
 give-NMLZ-POSS.3SG rumor-POSS.3SG-ACC hear-PST

²One might claim that the wh-remnants belong to separate clauses, separated by an intonational break, and therefore do not constitute a genuine instance of multiple sluicing, as has been argued for other cases of sluicing (see Hankamer 2011, Zidani-Eroğlu 2019, pace Kiper 2022). However, the availability of the optional subject in (8a) shows that the remnants are in fact contained within the same clause.

³Note that the copular clause in (8b) is degraded on the intended interpretation, where the clause identifies both the recipient and the theme of Çayan’s giving event.

‘Çayan heard the rumor that Figen gave someone a large amount of money’

- a. ama **kim-e** bil-mi-yor.
but who-DAT know-NEG-IPFV.3SG
‘but they do not know who.’
- b. *ama **kim-e-y-di** bil-mi-yor.
but who-DAT-AUX-PST know-NEG-IPFV.3SG
‘but they do not know who.’
- c. ve iş **arkadaş-ı-na-y-dı** san-ıyor.
and work friend-POSS.3SG-DAT-AUX-PST think-IPFV.3SG
‘and they think it was to their colleague.’

Finally, low sluicing allows wh-adjuncts corresponding to event modifiers in the antecedent, but copular clauses do not permit adjunct predicates, which have the relevant event structure. The contrast is exemplified in (10): the locative adjunct is possible in low sluicing, but the corresponding copular clause is degraded on the intended reading.

(10) Çayan Figen’le dün gece **bir yer-de** buluş-tu.
Çayan.NOM Figen.COM yesterday night one place-LOC meet-PST
‘Çayan met with Figen somewhere last night.’

- a. ama **nere-de-y-di** bil-mi-yor-um.
but where-LOC-AUX-PST know-NEG-IPFV-1SG
‘but I don’t know where.’
- b. *ve **park-ta-y-dı** san-dı-m.
and park-LOC-AUX-PST assume-PST-1SG
Int. ‘and I thought it was at the park.’

The diagnostics above rule out a uniform copular clause analysis of low sluicing. I now turn to the alternative analysis based on a full clausal source.

2.2 Full clause analysis

The fact that low sluicing cannot be reduced to copular clauses motivates an analysis in which the remnant is derived from a full clausal source. I refer to this as the *full clause analysis*, as illustrated in (11).

(11) [CP [TP [AUXP WH [αP [VoiceP SUBJ [vP ... WH ...] Voice] a] Aux^[E]] T] C]

I adopt the central intuition behind standard movement and deletion analysis of sluicing (Merchant 2001): the wh-remnant moves out of the ellipsis site, after which the remaining material is deleted under identity with an antecedent. This analysis has two crucial components. The first concerns the size of the ellipsis site: low sluicing deletes a constituent

smaller than TP, namely the complement of Aux. The second concerns the nature of the movement: the wh-remnant moves to the edge of AuxP to survive ellipsis. I discuss each component in turn.

The size of the ellipsis site differentiates low sluicing from high sluicing. In high sluicing, non-elided material consists only of a wh-phrase with case morphology, which can be analyzed as TP-ellipsis broadly parallel to sluicing in English (see Merchant 2001 for English; Ince 2009, Ince 2012 for Turkish). Low sluicing, on the other hand, contains auxiliary and tense on the remnant, which means the ellipsis site is smaller than a TP. Put differently, the more functional structure survives on the remnant, the less structure there is in the ellipsis site.

The fact that sluicing strings may involve deletion of a smaller constituent such as AspP-ellipsis licensed by T has been argued for in previous work (see Ince 2006 for Turkish; van Craenenbroeck and Lipták 2008 for Hungarian). I adopt the central insight of these accounts but depart from them in both the ellipsis site and the licensing head. I propose that low sluicing involves the deletion of a deverbal projection, which I label *aP* and that this deletion is licensed by Aux, the head that hosts the copular morpheme. The motivation for this structure comes from independent properties of the verbal spine in Turkish. Finite morphology (e.g., past, evidential tenses) may attach directly to a root, but must follow the copular morpheme when the predicate is non-verbal or deverbal (e.g., a stem inflected with imperfective) (Kornfilt 1996, Sağ 2013, Keleş 2021). I take this to indicate that certain aspectual/modal layers close off the verbal complex forming a deverbal predicate, while Aux introduces the verbal layer required by finite tense.⁴ For present purposes, I do not take the distribution of the copular morpheme to decide between a postsyntactic insertion analysis and a syntactic-head analysis of Aux. I assume that Aux is syntactically instantiated though I do not commit to a particular implementation (e.g., Pietraszko 2023, pace Bjorkman 2011). The copular morpheme realizes an Aux head that verbalizes a deverbal *aP*, and serves as the licensing head in low sluicing.

Given this structure, the remaining question is why the wh-remnant moves out of the ellipsis site. For wh-fronting languages, the relevant movement is relatively straightforward since wh-phrases independently move to the left periphery in constituent questions. Turkish, however, is an in-situ language and does not have obligatory overt wh-movement. The analysis therefore requires an independent explanation for the wh-extraction. For this reason, previous movement and deletion analyses of sluicing in Turkish have treated this extraction as focus-driven à la Toosarvandani (2008) (e.g., Ince 2006, 2009, 2012, Kiper 2020, 2022 pace Şener 2012, Palaz 2018). There is, however, independent evidence that focus in Turkish does not involve movement to the left periphery (Kiliçaslan 2004, Kamali and Krifka 2020). Following this line of work, I assume that focus is licensed either prosodically in situ or in the preverbal position (Göksel and Özsoy 2000). I therefore take the movement involved in low sluicing to be *ellipsis-driven*, not focus-driven: the remnant moves to the specifier of the licensing head because it must be outside the silenced constituent to be pronounced.

⁴Kornfilt (1996) also shows that this copular form, though covert, is present on non-verbal and deverbal forms even when there is no finite morphology.

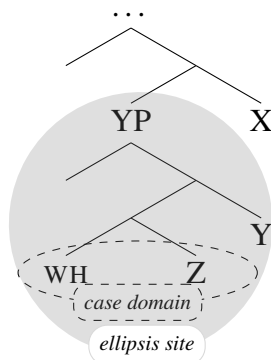
3. The proposal

Low sluicing in Turkish has a clausal source parallel to its antecedent. The same kinds of syntactic dependencies that yield case marking on the correlate in the antecedent clause are therefore present in the source of the elliptical question. This creates a tension: if the source contains the configurations in which accusative and genitive are normally assigned, why do wh-remnants fail to bear these cases?

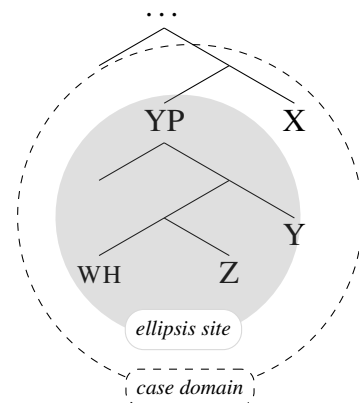
I propose that the answer lies in the timing of ellipsis licensing relative to case computation. For wh-remnants to surface without the structural case borne by their correlates, the ellipsis-licensing head must render part of the structure inaccessible before the relevant case assignment occurs. This contrasts with cases assigned local enough to escape ellipsis (e.g., dative in 6). Regardless of the particular theory of case one adopts, these are assigned within the lower domain and thus are already available before the structure is targeted by ellipsis. Structural cases, by contrast, depend on larger configurational relations that are established outside the ellipsis site.

The central claim is that structural case fails to surface on low sluicing remnants when the ellipsis domain is structurally lower than the relevant case domain. When subsequent case computation applies, DPs inside the ellipsis site have been rendered inaccessible by the licensing head. The schematic contrast in (12)–(13) illustrates the basic idea. In a case-connectivity configuration, the relevant case relation is established inside the ellipsis site. Since the case relation is local to the elided constituent, the wh-remnant surfaces with the expected case. In a case-disconnectivity configuration, on the other hand, the ellipsis site is properly contained within a larger case domain. The wh-phrase is base-generated inside the ellipsis site, while the configuration responsible for assigning structural case is established only outside it. Once ellipsis is licensed, the remnant inside its complement is no longer accessible to that later case computation. Case disconnectivity therefore arises not because the elided clause lacks the relevant structure, but because ellipsis affects the derivational accessibility of that structure.

(12) *case connectivity*



(13) *case disconnectivity*



The proposal therefore requires two ingredients. The first is a theory of ellipsis in which the [E]-feature affects not only the pronunciation, but also the syntactic derivation. The

second is a theory of case in which accusative and genitive are assigned configurationally. I spell out these two ingredients in turn.

3.1 What ellipsis-licensing can do

Ellipsis is governed by two conditions: an identity condition and a licensing condition (Lobeck 1995, Merchant 2001, 2018). The identity condition requires that the elided material be recoverable from its antecedent, an idea most influentially implemented through e-GIVENness (Schwarzschild 1999, Merchant 2001). I set this condition aside here and focus on the licensing condition since the case-disconnectivity puzzle bears on the derivational effect of the ellipsis-licensing head.

The licensing condition specifies the syntactic environments in which ellipsis can occur. Sluicing is tied to an interrogative structure: TP-ellipsis is possible only when the clause contains the relevant WH and Q feature. In earlier approaches, this dependence is captured through the relation between the C head and an overt wh-phrase (Lobeck 1995). Merchant (2001) implements the same intuition by locating the [E]-feature on the licensing head C, which triggers the deletion of its complement at PF. The wh-remnant is thus central to the licensing configuration, but it is not itself the element that hosts the ellipsis feature. Instead, [E]-feature is bundled with WH and Q features. The syntax of [E]-feature for sluicing is given in (14) (see Merchant 2001 for more details).

(14) The syntax of E_S : $E_S [uWH^*, uQ^*]$

I adopt this aspect of Merchant's (2001) analysis: ellipsis is triggered by a formal feature [E] bundled with WH-feature on the licensing head whose complement is the ellipsis site. For low sluicing in Turkish, however, the licensing head cannot be C. Low sluicing remnants surface with more material compared to high sluicing. This indicates that the ellipsis site is lower than the functional heads realizing Aux and T. Thus, the [E]-feature is hosted by Aux, the licensing head bearing the copular morphology visible on the remnant as argued in Section 2. Aux licenses the non-pronunciation of its complement αP .

The crucial question for the present proposal is what the [E]-feature does. In a purely PF-oriented view, [E] instructs PF not to pronounce the relevant constituent. This is not enough to derive the case-disconnectivity pattern. If the elided structure remains fully accessible for all case computation, only to be silenced at PF, then a wh-remnant inside a clausal source should still be able to enter into the structural case relations available in that source. The absence of accusative and genitive case on low sluicing remnants therefore requires a stronger view of ellipsis licensing.

A related proposal comes from Aelbrecht (2010), who argues that ellipsis licensing has consequences during the derivation. Their motivation comes from extraction asymmetries in ellipsis: if ellipsis were simply an operation at PF, the extraction out of the ellipsis site should be possible within syntax. Aelbrecht (2010), however, proposes that ellipsis takes effect as soon as the licensing relation is established, making the ellipsis site inaccessible for further syntactic operations.

I follow the broader insight in Aelbrecht (2010), but not the full mechanism. In the current account, the licensing head does not render its complement opaque for all syntactic operations, and instead makes it inaccessible for subsequent case computation. This means that ellipsis licensing does more than instruct PF to not pronounce material (or not insert vocabulary in Aelbrecht's 2010 sense). It creates a derivational opacity whose consequences depend on when case is calculated. I now turn to the theory of case necessary for this interaction.

3.2 Case computation

A central question in syntactic theory is how structural case is assigned. On one view, structural case is licensed by functional heads such as v or T, typically through AGREE, also known as *Functional Head Case Theory* (FHCT) (Chomsky 2000, 2001). On another view, structural case is assigned configurationally based on competition among DPs in a local domain. This is the core idea of Dependent Case Theory (DCT) where cases such as accusative are assigned when two DPs stand in a c-command relation within the same case domain (Marantz 1991, Baker and Vinokurova 2010, Baker 2015).

The facts of low sluicing pose a serious timing problem for FHCT. Under the standard implementation, accusative case is assigned by a v head. Genitive case on subjects of nominalizations, on the other hand, is often analyzed as assigned by a nominal head such as D (e.g., Kornfilt 2008, Miyagawa 2011). Since both functional heads are contained inside the constituent targeted by ellipsis, the relevant DPs should already have been assigned accusative and genitive before the licensing head, Aux, is merged as schematized in (15) and (16) respectively. This incorrectly predicts unattested case connectivity where accusative and genitive survive on low sluicing remnants.

$$(15) \quad [_{CP} WH_i [_{TP} [_{AuxP} [_{aP} [_{vP} SUBJ [_{vP} WH_i^{u[-]} V] v^{u[ACC]}] a] \textcircled{2} Aux^{[E]}] T] C]$$

$$(16) \quad [_{CP} WH_i \dots [_{AuxP} [_{aP} \dots [_{DP} \dots [_{vP} WH_i^{u[-]} \dots] D^{u[GEN]}] \dots] \textcircled{2} Aux^{[E]}] \dots C]$$

I propose that the alternative is provided by DCT in which structural case is computed configurationally (Marantz 1991). With the analysis of low sluicing based on movement and deletion, DCT creates room for the licensing head to merge first and render its complement inaccessible for later case computation.

Following the disjunctive case hierarchy in Marantz (1991), I assume that lexical/inherent cases are assigned first by local heads, dependent case is assigned next and unmarked case is assigned last. This explains the contrast between cases that survive and those that cannot: locally assigned cases such as dative or locative are already available before Aux licenses ellipsis and thus survive on the remnant. Structural cases, by contrast, may fail to be assigned if the configuration is disrupted by ellipsis. I state the two rules relevant for the analysis in (17)–(18).

- (17) **DEPENDENT CASE ASSIGNMENT**
 Within TP, when two distinct, caseless DPs are in a c-command relationship, the lower, c-commanded DP is assigned accusative case.
- (18) **UNMARKED CASE ASSIGNMENT**
 Any DP that has not been assigned lexical or dependent case is assigned unmarked case, realized morphologically as nominative in clausal domains and genitive in nominal domains.

The rule in (17) follows the insight in Baker and Vinokurova (2010): accusative is downward dependent case. The rule in (18) captures the fact that DPs which do not receive lexical or dependent case are not left unlicensed; they receive unmarked case appropriate to their syntactic environment. Thus, a caseless DP in a clausal domain surfaces as nominative whereas a caseless DP in a nominal domain surfaces as genitive.⁵

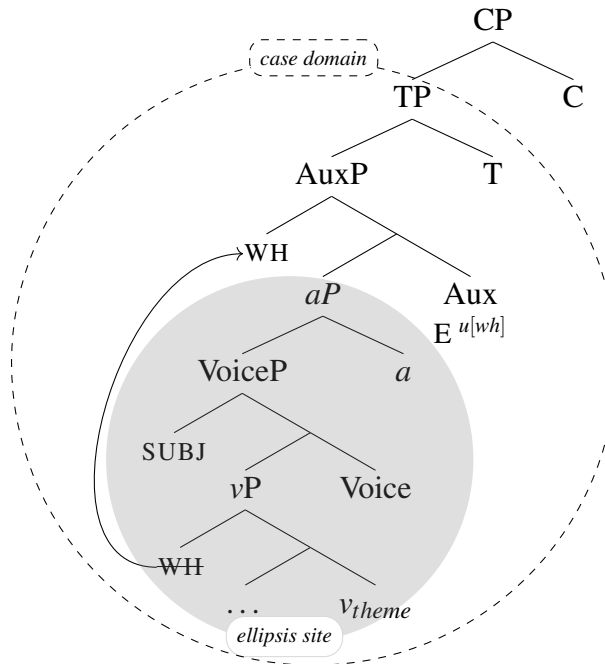
4. The analysis

In this section, I show how the interaction between ellipsis licensing leads to the case-disconnectivity pattern under DCT. I begin with accusative. In a non-elliptical transitive clause, the subject and object enter into competition within the TP case domain. The lower of the two caseless DPs, namely the object, is assigned dependent case. This is what happens in the antecedent clause in (2), where the correlate surfaces with accusative.

The elliptical clause is different. As illustrated in (19), once merged, the licensing head Aux freezes its complement *aP* for subsequent case computation and marks it for non-pronunciation at PF. This freezing effect is restricted to case calculation, and thus does not block the extraction. The *wh*-object then moves to [Spec *AuxP*] to satisfy the strong WH-feature bundled with [E] and to survive ellipsis. When TP is later evaluated for dependent case, the *wh*-remnant cannot enter into the relevant case competition with the subject, because the subject is contained inside the domain rendered inaccessible by Aux. Since there is no accessible DP competitor, the *wh*-remnant receives unmarked case instead of accusative and is realized as nominative in the clausal domain. This yields *kim-di*, rather than **kim-i-y-di*.

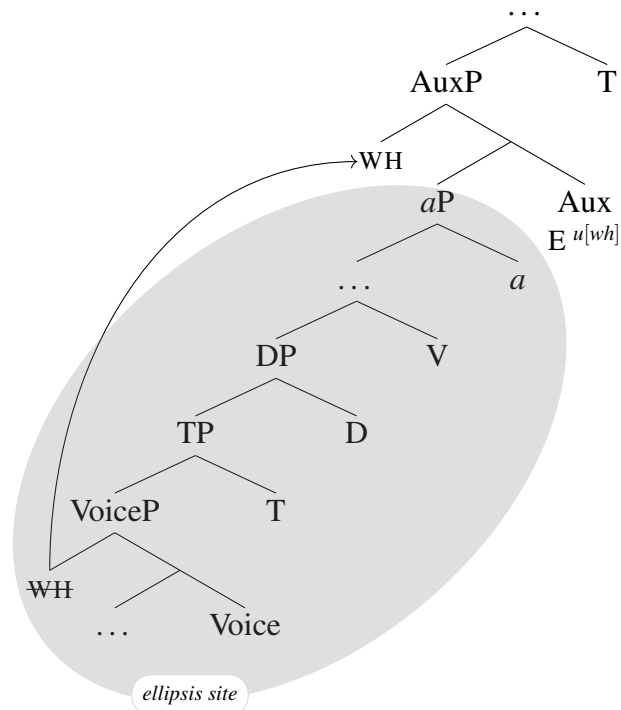
⁵I remain neutral here about the relationship between case domains and phases. The analysis is compatible with a cyclic view of dependent case, but incompatible with a strong version of Phase Impenetrability Condition where lower material is transferred to PF before Aux licenses ellipsis.

(19)



A similar, though slightly different, logic extends to subjects of nominalized clauses. In a non-elliptical nominalization, once lexical and dependent case assignment have applied, the embedded subject is evaluated inside a nominal domain and receives unmarked case, realized as genitive. This is the mechanism at play in the antecedent clause in (3), where the correlate bears genitive.

In low sluicing, however, Aux renders its complement, *aP*, inaccessible for subsequent case computation and marks it for non-pronunciation as illustrated in (20). The *wh*-subject moves out of the ellipsis site to satisfy the WH-feature and escape the ellipsis. The nominalized clause containing the lower copy of the *wh*-subject is inside this inaccessible domain. As a result, the pronounced *wh*-remnant is not evaluated as a DP remaining in the relevant nominal case domain. It is instead evaluated in the higher clausal domain, where unmarked case is realized as nominative. This yields *kim-di* rather than **kim-in-di*.



In this paper, I argued that low sluicing provides new leverage for the configurational theory of case assignment. Based on the unacceptable accusative- and genitive-marked low sluicing remnants, I proposed that the ellipsis-licensing head freezes its complement for case computation, making material inside the ellipsis site unavailable for case competition. As a result, the *wh*-remnant cannot enter into the configurational relations required for structural case and instead receives unmarked case, spelled out as nominative.

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